



Eating for Stable Blood Sugar

A Practical Guide for Diabetics

A friendly, practical handbook for people living with
Type 1, Type 2, and pre-diabetes

Published by DiaFitus | May 2026
Exercise Program for Diabetes Wellness



What's inside

Introduction	Why food is your most powerful tool
Chapter 1	How food affects blood sugar
Chapter 2	The diabetic plate method
Chapter 3	Your 7-day meal plan
Chapter 4	20 foods to prioritize
Chapter 5	Foods to limit (and what to swap in)
Chapter 6	Eating around exercise
Chapter 7	Reading labels & eating out
Chapter 8	Hydration & fasting
Closing	A note to take with you

How to use this guide. You don't have to read it cover to cover or change everything at once. Pick one chapter, try one idea this week, and let it settle. Small, repeated choices are what move your numbers - not a perfect week followed by giving up. Come back to any section whenever you need it.



Introduction

Food is your most powerful tool

If you live with diabetes or pre-diabetes, you've probably been handed a lot of rules. Eat this, not that. Count these. Avoid those. It can start to feel like food is the enemy - something to be managed, feared, and apologized for. This guide takes a different view. Food is not your enemy. It is, in fact, the single most powerful and immediate tool you have for keeping your blood sugar steady. More than that, it's something you get to enjoy several times a day, every day, for the rest of your life.

Here's the simple truth that this whole guide is built on: every time you eat, you're making a choice that affects your blood sugar over the next few hours. That's not a reason for guilt - it's a reason for hope. It means you have real influence, several times a day, over how you feel and how your body manages glucose. Medication matters. Movement matters. But what's on your plate is the lever you control most directly, three or more times a day.

Why food works faster than almost anything else

When you eat, your body breaks much of that food down into glucose - sugar - which enters your bloodstream. In a body without diabetes, the hormone insulin shuttles that glucose into cells smoothly and quietly. With diabetes, that process is either missing (Type 1) or sluggish and overwhelmed (Type 2 and pre-diabetes). So the glucose lingers in the blood, climbing higher and staying up longer than it should.

This is why the same meal can affect two people completely differently - and why what you eat is so powerful. You can't instantly change how much insulin your body makes. But you absolutely can change how much glucose arrives, and how quickly. A plate that delivers glucose slowly and gently gives your body a fighting chance to keep up. A plate that dumps a flood of fast sugar all at once does the opposite. Same hunger, same meal slot - very different result.

KEY The big idea in one breath

- You can't always control how your body handles glucose - but you can control how much arrives and how fast.
- Slower, gentler glucose = steadier blood sugar = more energy and fewer crashes.
- This is true whether you have Type 1, Type 2, or pre-diabetes. The details differ; the principle doesn't.

The link between what you eat and how you feel

Blood sugar isn't just a number on a meter - it's something you feel in your body all day long. When your glucose spikes after a big plate of fast carbs and then crashes an hour or two later, that crash has a name in everyday life: the afternoon slump, the 3 p.m. need for coffee and a cookie, the irritability before dinner, the foggy head in a meeting. Many people spend years assuming that's just how life feels, when a lot of it



is the roller-coaster of blood sugar rising and falling sharply.

When your meals keep glucose in a steadier range, the difference can be striking. Energy that lasts through the afternoon instead of collapsing. A clearer head. Fewer cravings, because you're not chasing the next sugar rebound. Better sleep. A calmer mood. Over months and years, steadier blood sugar also lowers the long-term risks that come with diabetes. But you don't have to wait years to feel the payoff - many people notice a difference within days of eating for stability.



It's worth saying clearly: this is not about willpower or being 'good.' It's about understanding how food works so you can set yourself up to win. When you know why a handful of nuts before a meal out can blunt a spike, or why adding vegetables and protein to your rice changes everything, you're not relying on motivation - you're using knowledge. Knowledge is far more reliable than willpower, and it doesn't run out at the end of a long day.

Who this guide is for

This guide is written for anyone managing blood sugar - Type 1, Type 2, or pre-diabetes. The foundations of eating for stable glucose are remarkably similar across all three. Where the advice genuinely differs - for example, how to fuel exercise when you take insulin versus when you don't - we'll call it out clearly so you know which parts apply to you.

An important note before we start. This is an educational guide, not medical advice, and it doesn't replace your doctor, endocrinologist, or diabetes care team. Diabetes is personal - your medications, your targets, and your body are unique to you. Use these ideas as a starting point for conversations with your care team, especially before making big changes if you take insulin or other glucose-lowering medication. You'll find a fuller disclaimer at the back.

Throughout, you'll find real food - not just theory. Actual breakfasts, lunches, dinners, and snacks. Specific swaps you can make at the supermarket. Things to look for on a menu. The goal is that you close this guide knowing exactly what to do at your next meal, not just understanding the science in the abstract. Let's start with how food actually moves your blood sugar - because once you see it, you can't unsee it, and every meal gets easier to navigate.

START Before you turn the page

- Pick one meal - just one - where you'd like to feel steadier. Breakfast is a great place to start for most people.
- As you read Chapter 1, picture that meal. You'll start spotting small changes almost immediately.
- Remember: consistency beats perfection. You're building a way of eating, not passing a test.



Chapter 1

How food affects blood sugar

Almost everything you eat falls into one of three groups: carbohydrates, protein, and fat. All three matter, but they affect your blood sugar in very different ways - and understanding those differences is the foundation of everything else in this guide. Once you understand it, you stop thinking in terms of 'good' and 'bad' foods and start thinking about how a meal is built.

Carbohydrates have the biggest and fastest effect on blood sugar, because your body breaks most of them down into glucose. Bread, rice, pasta, potatoes, fruit, milk, sugar, and sweets are all carbs. Protein and fat barely raise blood sugar on their own - and, importantly, they change how quickly the carbs you eat alongside them hit your bloodstream. That last point is the secret weapon we'll come back to again and again.

Not all carbs are created equal: glycemic index

The glycemic index, or GI, is a way of ranking carb-containing foods by how quickly they raise blood glucose. Foods are scored from 0 to 100. A high-GI food is digested fast and sends glucose surging into your blood - think a spike on a graph. A low-GI food is digested slowly and raises glucose gently, like a gentle hill instead of a cliff.

Here's the helpful part: foods you might think of as similar can sit at opposite ends of the scale. White bread and a boiled new potato are high-GI. Lentils, most beans, oats, and most whole fruits are low-GI. A baked potato spikes glucose faster than table sugar does. None of this means you can never eat a potato - it means knowing which foods spike you fast lets you plan around them.

Lower GI (gentler)	Higher GI (faster spike)
Lentils, chickpeas, kidney beans	White bread, white bagels
Steel-cut or rolled oats	Instant oats, sugary cereal
Most whole fruit (apple, berries, pear)	Watermelon, very ripe banana, fruit juice
Sweet potato (especially cooled)	White potato, especially mashed
Whole-grain or sourdough bread	White rice (regular)
Pasta cooked al dente	Soft, overcooked pasta

Why glycemic load matters even more

GI has one weakness: it only tells you how fast a food raises glucose, not how much carbohydrate is actually on your plate. Watermelon, for example, has a high GI, but a normal serving contains very little carbohydrate - so in real life it doesn't spike you the way the GI number suggests. This is where glycemic



load (GL) comes in. Glycemic load combines two things: how fast a food raises glucose (GI) and how much of it you actually eat. It's a far more realistic picture of what happens at a real meal.

You don't need to memorize numbers or do math at the table. The practical takeaway is simply this: both the type of carb and the amount matter. A small portion of a higher-GI food can be perfectly fine. A huge portion of even a 'healthy' carb can still spike you. Portion and quality work together.

TIP Putting GI and GL to work

- Favor low-GI carbs as your everyday default: beans, lentils, oats, whole fruit, whole grains.
- When you eat a higher-GI food, keep the portion modest and never eat it alone (more on this below).
- Don't fear whole fruit because of GI. Whole fruit comes with fiber and a reasonable glycemic load - juice does not.



How protein and fat slow the spike

Here's one of the most useful facts in this entire guide: the very same carbohydrate will raise your blood sugar more gently if you eat it alongside protein and fat. Protein and fat slow down how fast your stomach empties, which means the glucose from your meal trickles into your bloodstream over a longer period instead of arriving all at once. The spike gets flattened into a gentle rise.

Picture two breakfasts. Breakfast A is a bowl of cornflakes with skim milk and a glass of orange juice - almost pure fast carbohydrate with little to slow it down. Breakfast B is the same bowl of oats, but topped with a spoon of nut butter, a handful of nuts, and some Greek yogurt on the side. Breakfast B delivers similar carbs, but the protein and fat turn a sharp spike into a slow, manageable rise. You'll also feel full far longer - which means no mid-morning crash and crash-driven snacking.

A spike-prone meal	The steadier version
White toast with jam	Whole-grain toast with eggs and avocado
Plain white rice, large portion	Smaller rice + chicken + stir-fried veg
Pasta with tomato sauce only	Pasta (smaller) with meat sauce + side salad + olive oil
Rice cakes on their own	Rice cakes with cheese or peanut butter
Fruit smoothie / juice	Whole fruit + a handful of nuts

HABIT The 'never naked carbs' rule

- Try not to eat carbs 'naked' - on their own. Always pair them with protein, healthy fat, or fiber.
- A slice of toast becomes far gentler with eggs or nut butter. A bowl of rice becomes gentler with chicken and vegetables.
- This single habit - pairing every carb - is one of the most reliable ways to flatten spikes.

The quiet hero: fiber

Fiber is a type of carbohydrate your body can't fully digest - and that's exactly what makes it so valuable. Because it isn't broken down into glucose, fiber adds almost nothing to your blood sugar. Better still, it physically slows the digestion of the other carbs around it, much like protein and fat do. Soluble fiber, the kind in oats, beans, apples, and chia seeds, forms a gel in your gut that slows everything down and feeds the helpful bacteria living there.



Fiber does several jobs at once for blood sugar. It blunts the post-meal rise. It keeps you full, so you naturally eat less without feeling deprived. And over time, a high-fiber way of eating is linked to better long-term glucose control. The catch is that most people eat nowhere near enough of it. Refined, processed foods have had most of their fiber stripped out - which is a big part of why they spike blood sugar so sharply.

Easy ways to get more fiber

You don't need supplements or special products. Real, whole foods are loaded with fiber: vegetables, beans and lentils, whole fruit (with the skin where you can), whole grains, nuts, and seeds. The shift is mostly about choosing the less-processed version of foods you already eat - the whole-grain bread instead of white, the whole orange instead of the juice, the baked beans alongside instead of nothing.

TIP Building fiber into your day

- Add a vegetable to a meal that doesn't have one yet - even a handful of spinach into eggs or a side salad counts.
- Keep canned beans, lentils, or chickpeas on hand. Stir them into soups, salads, and sauces to add fiber and protein at once.
- Choose whole fruit over juice, and leave the skin on apples, pears, and potatoes when you can.
- Increase fiber gradually and drink more water as you do, so your gut adjusts comfortably.

Putting it all together

You now know the four levers that decide how a meal affects your blood sugar: the type of carb (its GI), the amount of carb (which drives glycemic load), and the protein, fat, and fiber you eat alongside it. You don't need to track or calculate any of this. You just need to build meals that lean on the gentle side of each lever - low-GI carbs in sensible portions, always paired with protein, fat, and fiber. That's the whole game, and the next chapter turns it into a picture you can see on your plate.

A note for Type 1 readers. If you count carbs and dose insulin, these principles still help you enormously - meals that release glucose slowly are easier to match with insulin and lead to fewer highs and lows. But your carb counting and insulin timing should always follow the plan you've worked out with your diabetes team. Use this chapter to build steadier meals, not to change your insulin approach on your own.

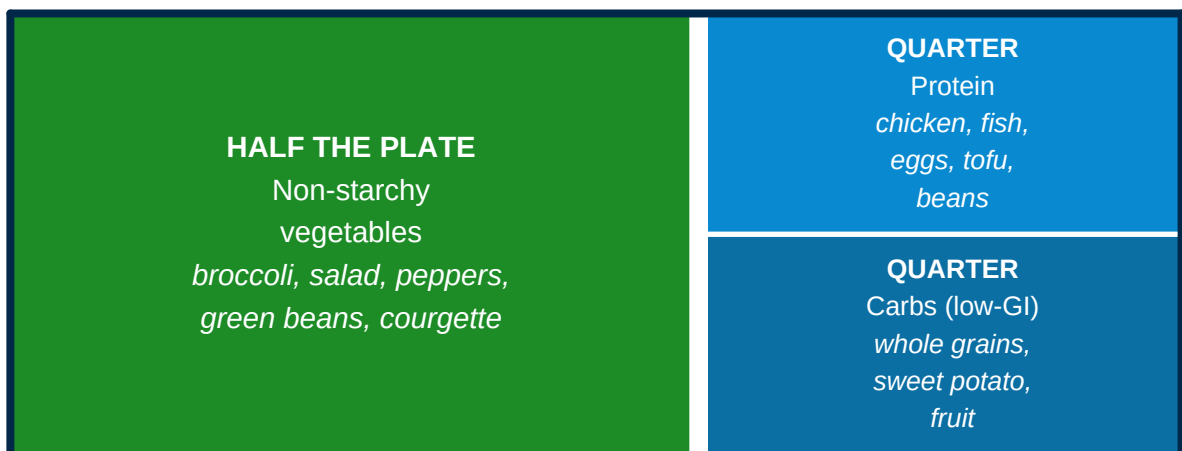


Chapter 2

The diabetic plate method

Everything in Chapter 1 - low-GI carbs, sensible portions, pairing carbs with protein, fat, and fiber - can feel like a lot to juggle at every meal. The plate method exists so you never have to juggle. Instead of counting or calculating, you just look at your plate and check the proportions. It's the simplest, most forgiving tool in diabetes nutrition, and it works in a restaurant, at a buffet, or at your own kitchen table.

The idea is beautifully simple. Take a normal-sized dinner plate - about 9 inches across, which is smaller than many modern plates. Then divide it into three sections: half for non-starchy vegetables, a quarter for protein, and a quarter for carbohydrate foods. That's it. Get those proportions roughly right and you've automatically built a meal that releases glucose slowly, fills you up, and keeps portions in check - without a single calculation.



Your plate at a glance: half non-starchy vegetables (green), a quarter protein (blue, top), a quarter low-GI carbs (blue, bottom). Add a thumb of healthy fat and a glass of water.

Half the plate: non-starchy vegetables

This is the foundation, and the part most of us under-fill. Non-starchy vegetables are low in carbs, rich in fiber, and packed with nutrients - so they fill half your plate while barely touching your blood sugar. They're the reason the plate method works: that big pile of vegetables physically displaces what would otherwise be a mountain of rice or pasta, and the fiber slows everything else down.

Think leafy greens, broccoli, cauliflower, peppers, courgette (zucchini), green beans, mushrooms, tomatoes, cucumber, cabbage, asparagus, and salad leaves. Cooked or raw, fresh or frozen - all count. The only vegetables that don't go in this half are the starchy ones (potato, corn, peas), which behave more like carbs and belong in the carb quarter.



A quarter of the plate: protein

Protein is the steady anchor of the meal. It barely raises blood sugar, it keeps you full for hours, and it slows the digestion of the carbs sharing the plate. A portion roughly the size of your palm is a good visual guide for most people. You don't need to weigh it.

Good choices include chicken, turkey, fish and seafood, eggs, tofu and tempeh, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, and beans or lentils. Beans and lentils are a two-for-one: they count as protein and provide fiber-rich, low-GI carbohydrate at the same time, which is why they're so prized in diabetes eating.

A quarter of the plate: carbohydrate foods

Carbs are not banned - they're portioned. Keeping starchy foods and grains to a quarter of the plate naturally controls the amount of glucose the meal delivers, which is the single biggest factor in how high your blood sugar climbs afterward. Fill this quarter with the lower-GI options from Chapter 1: whole grains, sweet potato, beans, whole-grain bread, or fruit.

Notice what the plate method quietly does. By capping carbs at a quarter and filling half the plate with vegetables, it enforces both lessons from Chapter 1 at once - smaller carb portions and plenty of fiber - without you having to think about either.

RULE Plate method quick rules

- Use a 9-inch plate. A bigger plate quietly invites bigger portions of everything.
- Fill the vegetable half first. Whatever's left decides how much room carbs get.
- Protein = roughly a palm-sized portion. Carbs = roughly a cupped-handful or fist.
- Add a small amount of healthy fat - a drizzle of olive oil, a few nuts, some avocado - for flavor and a gentler rise.

Portion sizes without a scale

You will almost never have measuring cups when you actually eat, so the most useful portion guides are the ones attached to your own body. Your hand travels with you everywhere and scales to your size.

Use your hand	Roughly equals	Good for
Palm (not fingers)	A protein portion	Chicken, fish, tofu, meat
Cupped hand	One carb portion	Rice, pasta, oats, beans
Fist	One vegetable portion	Salad, broccoli, mixed veg
Thumb	One fat portion	Oil, butter, nut butter, cheese



Adjusting the plate for different meals

The half-quarter-quarter split is your dinner default, but real life has breakfasts, snacks, and lighter meals. The proportions flex; the principles stay the same. Whatever the meal, the questions are always: where's my protein, where's my fiber, and is the carb portion sensible?

Breakfast

Breakfast is often the most carb-heavy, vegetable-free meal of the day - cereal, toast, pastries - which is exactly why so many people spike in the morning. You don't need salad at 7 a.m., but do anchor breakfast with protein and fat: eggs, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, or nut butter. Aim for roughly half the plate as protein and fat, a quarter as a low-GI carb like oats or whole-grain toast, and a quarter as fruit or vegetables (a handful of berries, some spinach in your eggs, tomatoes on the side).

Lunch and dinner

These are where the classic half-quarter-quarter plate shines. A bowl meal works the same way - just build it in the same proportions: a base of leaves and vegetables, a palm of protein on top, a cupped handful of grains, and a drizzle of dressing or oil. Soups, stir-fries, and curries all bend to the same logic: more vegetables and protein, a controlled scoop of rice or bread.

Snacks

Snacks trip up more people than meals do, because they're usually eaten on autopilot and are almost always naked carbs - crackers, fruit alone, a biscuit with coffee. The plate method shrinks down to a simple pairing rule for snacks: always combine a carb with a protein or fat. Apple with peanut butter. Crackers with cheese. Berries with Greek yogurt. Veg sticks with hummus. The pairing turns a spike-prone nibble into a steady one.

SNACK Snack pairings that hold steady

- Apple or pear slices + a spoon of peanut or almond butter.
- A small handful of nuts + a few berries.
- Greek yogurt + a sprinkle of seeds or chopped nuts.
- Vegetable sticks + hummus or guacamole.
- Whole-grain crackers + cheese or cottage cheese.

The plate method is a guide, not a ruler. You don't need to measure angles or feel guilty if tonight's plate is 40 percent carbs. The goal is to nudge most of your meals in this direction, most of the time. A plate that's roughly right, eaten consistently, beats a perfect plate you can't sustain. Keep the picture in your head and let it guide you - that's enough.



Chapter 3

Your 7-day meal plan

Here's a full week of meals built on everything from the first two chapters: low-GI carbs in sensible portions, every carb paired with protein, fat, and fiber, and plenty of non-starchy vegetables. Think of it as a template, not a prescription. Swap any meal for another from the same slot, repeat your favorites, and adjust portions to your appetite and your care team's guidance.

About the carb counts. The carb numbers are approximate, in grams, for one serving - rounded and meant as a rough guide, not a lab measurement. They're here so you can see how the plan keeps carbs moderate and spread across the day. **If you count carbs for insulin dosing, use your own weighed amounts and your team's ratios - not these estimates.** Everyone's portions and needs differ.

GUIDE How to read the week

- Each day has breakfast, lunch, dinner, and one or two snacks - roughly 110-150g of carbs total, spread out to avoid big spikes.
- Every meal pairs carbs with protein and/or fat on purpose. That pairing is doing the heavy lifting.
- Drink water with every meal. Unsweetened tea or coffee is fine too.

**Day 1** Easing in

Meal	What to eat	Carbs
Breakfast	Scrambled eggs with spinach and mushrooms, 1 slice whole-grain toast, half an avocado	~20g
Lunch	Grilled chicken salad: leaves, peppers, cucumber, chickpeas, olive oil & lemon dressing	~25g
Snack	Greek yogurt (unsweetened) with a small handful of berries	~12g
Dinner	Baked salmon, roasted broccoli & courgette, half-cup quinoa	~30g

Glucose-friendly tip: Eating your salad and protein before the chickpeas slightly blunts the glucose rise. Order or plate veg and protein first, carbs last.

Day 2 Plant-forward

Meal	What to eat	Carbs
Breakfast	Overnight oats (rolled oats, chia seeds, unsweetened milk) topped with chopped nuts and a few raspberries	~28g
Lunch	Lentil and vegetable soup with a slice of sourdough and a wedge of cheese	~30g
Snack	Apple slices with 1 tbsp peanut butter	~18g
Dinner	Stir-fried tofu with mixed vegetables and a small portion of brown rice	~32g

Glucose-friendly tip: Chia seeds in the oats add soluble fiber that slows digestion. A short walk after dinner helps soak up the rice's glucose.



Day 3 Comfort, rebuilt		
Meal	What to eat	Carbs
Breakfast	Greek yogurt bowl with berries, a spoon of nut butter, and a sprinkle of seeds	~18g
Lunch	Whole-grain wrap with turkey, hummus, lettuce, tomato; side of cucumber sticks	~30g
Snack	A small handful of almonds and a few cherry tomatoes	~6g
Dinner	Lean beef chili with kidney beans, served over cauliflower rice with a green salad	~28g

Glucose-friendly tip: Swapping half the usual rice for cauliflower rice cuts the carb load without cutting the comfort. The beans add slow, fiber-rich carbs.

**Day 4** Quick and steady

Meal	What to eat	Carbs
Breakfast	Veggie omelette (peppers, onion, spinach) with a side of avocado	~8g
Lunch	Tuna salad (tuna, olive oil mayo, celery) on a bed of leaves with whole-grain crackers	~22g
Snack	Cottage cheese with sliced pear	~15g
Dinner	Roast chicken thighs, roasted sweet potato, green beans with olive oil	~30g

Glucose-friendly tip: Sweet potato is lower-GI than white potato, especially when roasted and allowed to cool slightly. Keep the portion to a cupped handful.

Day 5 Mediterranean day

Meal	What to eat	Carbs
Breakfast	Whole-grain toast topped with mashed avocado, a poached egg, and chili flakes	~22g
Lunch	Greek salad (cucumber, tomato, olives, feta) with grilled chicken and a few whole-grain pita strips	~24g
Snack	Vegetable sticks with hummus	~12g
Dinner	Baked white fish with a tomato-and-pepper sauce, sauteed greens, half-cup whole-grain couscous	~30g

Glucose-friendly tip: Olive oil and the protein on each plate slow digestion all day. Vinegar in the salad dressing can also gently lower the post-meal rise.

Day 6 Relaxed weekend

Meal	What to eat	Carbs
Breakfast	Vegetable frittata (eggs, courgette, tomato, cheese) with a side of berries	~12g
Lunch	Big mixed bowl: leaves, roasted vegetables, chickpeas, grilled halloumi, olive oil dressing	~28g
Snack	A small square of dark chocolate (85%) with a few walnuts	~10g
Dinner	Homemade burgers (lean beef or turkey) wrapped in lettuce, with a side of sweet potato wedges	~26g

Glucose-friendly tip: A lettuce wrap instead of a bun saves around 25g of fast carbs. Dark chocolate at 85% satisfies a sweet craving with very little sugar.



Day 7 Batch-cook and reset		
Meal	What to eat	Carbs
Breakfast	Two-egg veggie scramble with smoked salmon and half an avocado	~6g
Lunch	Leftover chili (from Day 3) over a big green salad with avocado	~24g
Snack	Greek yogurt with cinnamon and a few blueberries	~14g
Dinner	Sheet-pan chicken with roasted peppers, onion, broccoli, and a small portion of new potatoes	~28g

Glucose-friendly tip: Cook extra tonight. Having a steady, ready-made meal in the fridge is the best defense against a spike-prone takeaway on a busy day.

Making the week work for you

Notice the patterns that repeat all week: a protein at every meal, vegetables at lunch and dinner, low-GI carbs in modest portions, and snacks that always pair a carb with a protein or fat. Those patterns are the real plan - the specific recipes are just examples. Once the patterns feel natural, you can build endless meals of your own without ever looking at this page again.

STICK Make the plan stick

- Cook once, eat twice: most dinners here make easy leftovers for the next day's lunch.
- Keep 'emergency' steady foods on hand - eggs, canned beans, frozen vegetables, Greek yogurt, nuts - for days the plan goes sideways.
- If you eat out, glance back at Chapter 7 and apply the plate method to the menu.
- Check your own glucose response if you're able to. Your meter is the ultimate guide to which meals suit your body.



Chapter 4

20 foods to prioritize

These are the foods worth building your week around. None is magic on its own - there's no single food that controls diabetes - but each one earns its place by either barely touching your blood sugar, slowing the digestion of other foods, or both. Lean on this list and the plate method takes care of itself. We've grouped them the same way you'd build a plate: vegetables, proteins, fats, and low-GI carbs.

Non-starchy vegetables (the half-plate heroes)

Almost free of impact on blood sugar, rich in fiber, and endlessly versatile. Eat them generously.

Food	Why it helps
1. Leafy greens	Spinach, kale, and lettuce are nearly carb-free, full of fiber and nutrients. The ultimate plate-filler.
2. Broccoli & cauliflower	High in fiber, very low in usable carbs. Cauliflower also stands in for rice or mash.
3. Peppers	Sweet, crunchy, and low-carb, with a big vitamin C hit. Great raw with hummus or roasted.
4. Courgette (zucchini)	Barely registers on blood sugar; makes a low-carb swap for pasta as 'courgetti'.
5. Tomatoes	Low in carbs and rich in antioxidants. The acidity can also gently slow a meal's glucose rise.



Lean proteins (the steady anchor)

Protein barely moves blood sugar and slows the digestion of the carbs beside it. Include some at every meal.

Food	Why it helps
6. Eggs	Cheap, filling, almost zero carbs. A protein-rich breakfast sets a steadier tone for the whole day.
7. Fish (especially oily)	Salmon, mackerel, and sardines add protein plus omega-3 fats that support heart health - important with diabetes.
8. Chicken & turkey	Lean, flexible, no carbs. A palm-sized portion anchors lunch or dinner.
9. Greek yogurt (unsweetened)	High in protein, low in carbs, and a perfect partner for fruit to keep snacks steady.
10. Tofu & tempeh	Plant proteins with minimal impact on glucose; soak up flavor and work in any stir-fry.

Healthy fats (slow and satisfying)

Fat adds almost nothing to blood sugar and slows everything else down. Use sensible amounts - it's calorie-dense.

Food	Why it helps
11. Avocado	Creamy, fiber-rich, and full of healthy fats. Slows a meal and keeps you full for hours.
12. Olive oil	A heart-friendly fat that lowers a meal's glycemic impact. Your default for cooking and dressings.
13. Nuts	Almonds, walnuts, and pistachios pair fat, protein, and fiber - a near-perfect steady snack in a small handful.
14. Seeds	Chia and flax are loaded with soluble fiber that forms a gel and slows glucose absorption.



Low-GI carbs (smart fuel, in portions)

Carbs you can build meals around - they release glucose slowly and bring fiber along for the ride.

Food	Why it helps
15. Beans & lentils	The diabetes superfood: low-GI carbs plus protein plus fiber, all in one. Add them anywhere.
16. Chickpeas	Same triple benefit as beans; roast them for a crunchy snack or blend into hummus.
17. Oats (rolled or steel-cut)	Soluble fiber (beta-glucan) gives a slow, steady rise - a far better breakfast than sugary cereal.
18. Berries	The lowest-sugar fruits, rich in fiber and antioxidants. Satisfy a sweet tooth with a small spike.
19. Sweet potato	More fiber and a lower GI than white potato, especially when cooled. A controlled portion is a great side.
20. Quinoa	A whole grain that's also a complete protein, with a gentler glucose curve than white rice.

USE How to use this list

- Build every plate from these four groups: load up vegetables, add a protein, include a little fat, choose a low-GI carb.
- Beans and lentils do double duty as protein and carb - keep cans in the cupboard at all times.
- Berries and dark chocolate (85%+) are your go-to when you want something sweet without a big spike.
- Variety matters - rotate within each group so meals stay interesting and you get a wider range of nutrients.

Remember: no food is off-limits forever, and no single food is a cure. Diabetes nutrition is about what you do most of the time. Fill your week mostly with the foods above, and the occasional meal outside the list won't undo your progress.



Chapter 5

Foods to limit (and what to swap in)

This isn't a list of forbidden foods. Calling foods 'forbidden' usually backfires - it builds craving and guilt, and neither helps your blood sugar. Instead, think of these as the foods that make stable glucose harder, the ones worth having less often and in smaller amounts. For each one, there's a satisfying swap that gives you the same comfort with a gentler effect. The goal is steadier defaults, not deprivation.

Refined carbs

White bread, white rice, regular pasta, pastries, and most breakfast cereals have had their fiber stripped away. What's left is fast-digesting starch that floods your bloodstream with glucose almost as quickly as sugar does. They're not evil - they're just the fastest route to a spike, and they leave you hungry again soon after.

Instead of...	Try this swap
White bread	Whole-grain, seeded, or sourdough bread
White rice	Brown rice, quinoa, or part-cauliflower rice
Regular pasta	Whole-grain pasta (cooked al dente) or a smaller portion + extra veg
Sugary breakfast cereal	Rolled oats or Greek yogurt with berries and nuts
Pastries / white bagels	Whole-grain toast with eggs or nut butter

Sugary drinks

Sugary drinks are the single fastest way to spike blood sugar. Soda, fruit juice, sweetened coffees, energy drinks, and sweet tea deliver a large dose of liquid sugar with nothing - no fiber, no fat, no protein - to slow it down. Because it's liquid, it hits almost instantly. Even '100% natural' fruit juice spikes glucose nearly as fast as soda; the fiber that made the whole fruit gentle has been squeezed out.



Instead of...	Try this swap
Soda / cola	Sparkling water with a squeeze of lemon or lime
Fruit juice	Whole fruit + water; or water infused with berries
Sweetened coffee drinks	Coffee with unsweetened milk; cinnamon for sweetness
Energy / sports drinks	Water; (sports drinks only if treating a genuine low or long, intense exercise)
Sweet iced tea	Unsweetened iced tea, plain or with mint

DRINK Drinks rule of thumb

- Make water your default drink. Aim to drink it with every meal.
- If you want flavor, infuse water with fruit, cucumber, or mint - the spike-free way to make it interesting.
- Save fast-acting sugary drinks for one job only: treating a genuine low blood sugar (if you take insulin or sulfonylureas).



Ultra-processed foods

Ultra-processed foods - packaged snacks, instant meals, sweets, many 'low-fat' products, processed meats, and most fast food - tend to combine refined carbs, added sugar, unhealthy fats, and salt, while being low in fiber. They're engineered to be easy to overeat, and they often spike blood sugar hard and fast. A useful habit: the longer and more unpronounceable the ingredient list, the more cautious it's worth being.

Instead of...	Try this swap
Potato chips / crisps	A handful of nuts, or roasted chickpeas
Sweets / candy	Berries, or a square of 85%+ dark chocolate
Instant noodles / ready meals	A quick stir-fry or an omelette with frozen veg (just as fast)
Biscuits / cookies with coffee	Greek yogurt with berries, or an oatcake with cheese
Fast-food burger meal	Homemade burger in a lettuce wrap with a side salad

SWAP Making swaps that actually last

- Swap one thing at a time. Trying to overhaul everything at once is the fastest way to give up.
- Don't keep your biggest temptation in the house. What's not in the cupboard can't be eaten on autopilot.
- Aim for 'better,' not 'perfect.' A whole-grain wrap with chips is a real improvement over white bread with chips.
- When you do eat a treat, pair it with protein or fat and enjoy it slowly - it'll spike you less and satisfy more.

This is not about guilt. A slice of birthday cake will not undo your progress. What matters is your everyday pattern, not the occasional celebration. If most of your meals lean toward the steady side, you have plenty of room for the foods you love on the days that matter. Stable blood sugar is built on consistency, not on a flawless record.



Chapter 6

Eating around exercise

Exercise is one of the best things you can do for blood sugar - it makes your body more sensitive to insulin and helps muscles pull glucose out of your blood. But movement also changes your glucose in the moment, and how you eat around it matters. This chapter is about fueling activity safely. Because this is where Type 1 and Type 2 genuinely differ, we'll flag which advice applies to whom.

Read this first. Exercise and food timing interact closely with diabetes medication, especially insulin and sulfonylureas. The guidance here is general and educational. Before changing how you eat or dose around exercise, talk with your diabetes team - they can tailor it to your medications and targets. As DiaFitus members know, this is exactly the kind of thing worth raising with us and your care team together.

Before exercise: avoiding a low

The main risk around exercise for many people on glucose-lowering medication is hypoglycemia - blood sugar dropping too low - during or after activity. The aim of pre-exercise food is to start with enough fuel in the tank so you don't drop too far. What you eat depends on how soon you'll move and how hard.

If you're exercising soon (within an hour)

For light activity like a gentle walk, you usually don't need to eat anything special. For something more demanding, a small snack that combines a quick carb with a little protein works well - for example, a banana with a spoon of peanut butter, or a small pot of Greek yogurt with berries. If you check your glucose and it's on the low side before starting, having some fast-acting carbohydrate first is sensible.

If you're exercising later (2-3 hours after a meal)

A balanced meal built on the plate method - protein, low-GI carbs, vegetables, and some fat - gives you steady, long-lasting fuel without a big spike beforehand. This is the ideal window for most planned workouts: you're neither running on empty nor riding a post-meal high.

PRE Pre-workout fueling

- Light, short activity: usually no extra food needed - a post-meal walk is perfect as is.
- Longer or harder sessions: a small carb-plus-protein snack 30-60 minutes before (banana + nut butter; yogurt + berries).
- If you check glucose and it's low before starting, treat it first with fast carbs and recheck before you begin.
- Carry fast-acting carbs (glucose tabs, juice) if you take insulin or sulfonylureas - always.



After exercise: recovering without spiking

After you move, your muscles are primed to soak up glucose to refill their energy stores - which is actually helpful for blood sugar. The goal after exercise is to support recovery with protein and some carbohydrate, without overdoing fast carbs and turning a healthy session into a spike. The same plate principles apply: pair your recovery carbs with protein.

A good recovery meal or snack might be Greek yogurt with berries and nuts, eggs on whole-grain toast, a chicken and vegetable bowl with some quinoa, or a smaller balanced version of any plate-method meal. Because your muscles are more insulin-sensitive for hours after exercise, this is often a time when carbs are handled more gently than usual - but that's a reason to choose good carbs, not a license to spike.

POST Post-workout recovery

- Pair protein with a modest amount of low-GI carbs: yogurt + berries, eggs + toast, or a balanced plate-method meal.
- Stay hydrated - rehydrating after exercise also supports healthy glucose levels.
- Watch for delayed lows: blood sugar can keep dropping for hours after exercise, sometimes overnight.
- If you take insulin, your team may advise adjusting doses or having a bedtime snack after evening exercise.

Type 1 vs Type 2: what's different

If you have Type 1 diabetes

Because you take insulin, the risk of hypoglycemia during and after exercise is real and needs active planning. Many people with Type 1 check glucose before, sometimes during, and after exercise, and carry fast-acting carbs every single time. Different activities affect you differently - steady cardio like jogging often lowers glucose, while short, intense bursts can temporarily raise it. Your insulin doses and timing around exercise should be worked out carefully with your diabetes team, and may need adjusting for planned activity. The food principles in this chapter support you, but they don't replace that personalized insulin planning.

If you have Type 2 diabetes or pre-diabetes

If you manage your diabetes with lifestyle alone or with medications that don't typically cause lows (such as metformin), your hypoglycemia risk during exercise is much lower, and you usually don't need to eat specially before moderate activity. For you, the biggest win is often the simplest: a 10-15 minute walk after meals, which blunts the post-meal glucose rise more effectively than almost anything else. If you take insulin or a sulfonylurea, though, treat the hypoglycemia precautions above as applying to you too.



Across both types: the post-meal walk is the most accessible, most effective habit in this whole guide. Ten to fifteen minutes of easy walking within half an hour of eating noticeably lowers your glucose spike - no equipment, no risk, available to almost everyone. If you take just one thing from this chapter, take that.



Chapter 7

Reading labels & eating out

Two situations trip people up most: the supermarket aisle and the restaurant table. Both are full of choices designed to be tempting, and both feel like they're outside your control. They're not. With a few simple habits, you can read a label in ten seconds and order a steady meal anywhere. This chapter gives you those habits.

How to read a food label

Food labels look busy, but for blood sugar you only need to look at a few things. Ignore the marketing on the front of the pack - 'low fat,' 'natural,' 'no added sugar' tell you very little about how a food affects glucose. Turn it over and look at the nutrition panel and ingredient list instead.

The three things to check first

Start with total carbohydrate per serving - this matters more than sugar alone, because all carbs turn into glucose. Then check fiber: higher fiber means a gentler effect, and some people subtract fiber from total carbs to estimate the carbs that truly count. Finally, glance at the serving size - labels often quote a tiny serving, so the carbs on a real portion may be double what's printed.

On the label	What to look for
Serving size	Check it's realistic - your real portion may be 2-3x this
Total carbohydrate	The number that matters most for blood sugar
of which sugars	Lower is better; watch for added sugars especially
Fiber	Higher is better - it blunts the glucose rise
Ingredient list	Short is good; sugar near the top is a red flag

Spotting hidden sugar

Sugar hides under many names in ingredient lists - syrups, anything ending in '-ose' (glucose, fructose, dextrose, maltose), concentrates, honey, and molasses all count. Ingredients are listed by weight, so if any form of sugar appears in the first three, the product is largely sugar - even if the front of the pack looks healthy.



LABEL Ten-second label check

- Flip to the back - the front of the pack is marketing, not information.
- Find total carbs per serving, then check the serving size is realistic.
- More fiber = gentler. Scan the ingredient list for sugar in the top three.
- Don't be fooled by 'low fat' - these are often higher in sugar to make up for taste.



Eating out without wrecking your blood sugar

Restaurants are absolutely doable - you just bring the plate method with you. Picture the half-quarter-quarter plate as you read the menu, and most decisions make themselves. The biggest levers when eating out are choosing a protein-and-vegetable-based dish, controlling the starchy sides, and being smart about drinks and the bread basket.

Ordering strategy

Look for grilled, baked, roasted, or steamed dishes built around a protein and vegetables. Ask for extra vegetables or a side salad in place of some of the fries, rice, or bread. You don't have to skip carbs entirely - just keep them to that quarter-plate portion and pair them with the protein and vegetables on the plate. Sauces and dressings on the side let you control hidden sugar.

Steadier choice	Spike-prone choice
Grilled chicken or fish + vegetables	Breaded, battered, or deep-fried mains
Side salad or extra veg	Large fries, garlic bread, big rice portion
Tomato- or olive-oil-based sauces	Sweet, sticky, or creamy sugary sauces
Water, sparkling water, unsweetened tea	Soda, juice, sweet cocktails
Berries or cheese to finish	Large dessert eaten on its own

DINE Restaurant survival kit

- Eat your protein and vegetables first, starch last - it gentles the spike even with the same food.
- Ask for sauces and dressings on the side, and swap some starch for extra veg or salad.
- Decide on the bread basket before it arrives; if you'll have some, pair it with olive oil, not on its own.
- If you want dessert, share one, or pick fruit or cheese - and take a short walk afterward.
- Cuisines built on vegetables and protein (Mediterranean, grilled, many Asian dishes) make steady ordering easy.

Eating out is part of life, not a failure. You can enjoy a meal out and keep your blood sugar reasonable - it just takes a glance at the menu through the plate-method lens. One indulgent meal is never the problem; it's the everyday pattern that shapes your numbers over time.



Chapter 8

Hydration & fasting

The quiet role of water

Water rarely gets mentioned in diabetes advice, but it plays a real supporting role. When blood sugar runs high, your body tries to flush the excess glucose out through your urine - which is why frequent urination and thirst are classic signs of high blood sugar. That process pulls water out of you, and dehydration can in turn concentrate your blood and nudge glucose readings higher. Staying well hydrated helps your body manage and clear glucose, and keeps everything working more smoothly.

There's a second, simpler reason water matters: it's the drink that replaces the spike-prone ones. Every glass of water with a meal is a glass that isn't soda or juice. Drinking water before meals can also help you feel full and avoid overeating. It's the easiest, cheapest, most underrated tool in the whole guide.

WATER Hydration habits

- Make water your default drink - with meals, at your desk, by your bed.
- Feeling unusually thirsty or urinating often can be a sign of high blood sugar - worth checking, not just drinking through.
- Infuse water with lemon, cucumber, berries, or mint if plain water bores you.
- Unsweetened tea and coffee count toward fluids; just watch what you add to them.

Is intermittent fasting safe for diabetics?

Intermittent fasting - eating within a limited window and fasting the rest of the day - has become popular, and some people with Type 2 diabetes or pre-diabetes find it helps with weight and blood sugar. But for people with diabetes, fasting is genuinely a 'talk to your doctor first' topic, not something to try on your own from a guide. The reason is simple: skipping meals while on certain medications can cause dangerous lows.

Why caution matters

If you take insulin or sulfonylureas, these medications lower your blood sugar whether or not you've eaten. Going long stretches without food while taking them can lead to hypoglycemia, which can be serious. Doses and timing usually need to be adjusted before any fasting is safe - and that adjustment must come from your diabetes team, never from guesswork. People with Type 1 diabetes in particular need careful medical supervision for any fasting, because of the constant insulin balance involved.



The honest answer: intermittent fasting *may* be safe and even helpful for some people with Type 2 diabetes or pre-diabetes - but only with medical guidance, and only after any medication adjustments. For people on insulin or sulfonylureas, and for anyone with Type 1, fasting carries real risk of hypoglycemia and must not be attempted without your doctor's involvement. Please don't start a fasting plan based on this guide alone.

A gentler middle ground

If the appeal of fasting is steadier blood sugar and better weight management, you can get much of that benefit from things this guide already covers - without the risk. Stopping eating a few hours before bed, avoiding constant grazing and late-night snacking, and spacing meals out so your glucose has time to settle between them all give your body real breaks from processing food. These are gentle, low-risk versions of the same idea, and they pair safely with the plate method.

FAST If fasting interests you

- Talk to your doctor or diabetes team before changing your eating window - especially if you take any glucose-lowering medication.
- Never skip meals on insulin or sulfonylureas without a medication plan from your team.
- Try the low-risk version first: a consistent overnight break from food and less late-night snacking.
- Keep monitoring your glucose and stop if you feel shaky, sweaty, or unwell - and treat lows immediately.



Closing

A note to take with you

If you've read this far, take a moment to notice something: you now understand more about how food affects your blood sugar than most people ever learn. You know that carbs raise glucose, that protein and fat and fiber slow it down, that portion and pairing matter more than any single 'good' or 'bad' food. You know how to build a plate, fill a week, read a label, order at a restaurant, and fuel a walk. That knowledge is yours now, and no one can take it back.

But here's the most important thing in this entire guide, and it's not a fact about food. It's this: you do not have to do this perfectly. You will have days when the plate is mostly carbs, when the dessert wins, when life is too busy for any of it. Those days are not failures. They're just days. What shapes your blood sugar - and your health - is not any single meal, but the gentle direction of your choices over weeks, months, and years.

Consistency beats perfection. Every single time.

A person who eats well 'most of the time' for a year will be far healthier than someone who eats flawlessly for two weeks and then gives up because they slipped. Progress in diabetes is not a straight line and it is never a test you pass or fail. It's a practice you return to, again and again, with a little more skill each time. Every meal is a fresh chance to nudge things in the right direction - and the next one is always just a few hours away.

So start small. Pick one idea from this guide - just one - and try it this week. Maybe it's pairing your toast with eggs. Maybe it's a ten-minute walk after dinner. Maybe it's swapping juice for water. Let that one change settle until it feels normal, then add another. This is how real, lasting change actually happens: not in a dramatic overhaul, but in one small, repeatable choice stacked on top of another.

Be patient and be kind to yourself. You're managing something that takes real attention every day, and the fact that you're learning how to do it better is something to be genuinely proud of. Your blood sugar will have good days and frustrating ones, and that's normal - keep going anyway. The direction matters far more than any single day's number.

"You don't have to be perfect. You just have to keep showing up."



You're not doing this alone. This guide is a starting point, not the last word. As a DiaFitus member, you can talk to us any time - log your meals and progress in your **Member Portal** at diafitus.com/login, leave a comment about anything you'd like help with, message us on **Telegram** through your admin page, or email support@diafitus.com. A real person will get back to you. We keep building and refining your plans as you progress, so tell us what's working and what isn't.

Communication is the most important part of the whole program. Here's to your next steady meal - and the many that follow.



Medical disclaimer

DiaFitus is a fitness and wellness planning resource, not a medical device, and this guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. Its contents are based on general nutrition principles consistent with guidance from organizations such as the American Diabetes Association (ADA).

This guide does not constitute medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment, and it is not a substitute for professional consultation with a licensed physician, endocrinologist, registered dietitian, or certified diabetes care and education specialist. Diabetes management is highly individual. Your medications, glucose targets, carbohydrate needs, and overall plan should be determined with your own healthcare team.

Talk to your healthcare provider before making significant changes to your diet, particularly if you take insulin or other glucose-lowering medications (such as sulfonylureas), as dietary changes, exercise, and fasting can affect your risk of hypoglycemia and may require medication adjustments. Carbohydrate counts in this guide are approximate estimates for general illustration and should not be used for insulin dosing in place of your own measurements and your team's ratios.

Seek medical attention if you experience symptoms of low blood sugar (shakiness, cold sweat, confusion, rapid heartbeat) that do not respond to fast-acting carbohydrates, or **symptoms of high blood sugar** (extreme thirst, frequent urination, fruity breath, nausea). If you ever feel seriously unwell, contact your healthcare provider or emergency services.

DiaFitus and the publisher of this guide disclaim all liability for any adverse outcome arising from the use of the information contained here. By using this guide you accept responsibility for your own health decisions and acknowledge that you have read and understood this disclaimer.

Eating for Stable Blood Sugar: A Practical Guide for Diabetics | Published by DiaFitus | Exercise Program for Diabetes Wellness | support@diafitus.com